

Sept 11, 2026 Bahaii Philosophy Group
“Habermas, Foucault and Baha’Ullah on Human Nature”

I decided to write this short script to begin the discussion today to give us something to cling on as begin to explore this difficult and complex subject. This is meant to be merely a synopsis to the discussion and not a treatise; in other words, this is merely a beginning to a way of posing the question in a broader sense.

Topics:

1. Kant’s Public and Private Distinction in “Was Ist Aufklärung” or What is Enlightenment
2. Habermas’ project: the public sphere
3. Foucault: A commentary on Kant’s “What is Enlightenment” and a response to Habermas
4. Baha’Ullah, the latest revelation, the “independent investiation” and the Tablet to the Christians and the Tablet of Wisdom; or, the Bahaii teaching on the Abrahamic tradition and the philosophical tradition

Topic 1: Kant - Public and Private Distinction

As we saw last week, in Kant’s seminal essay “What is Enlightenment” we have a theory of the political which describes our relationship to modernity, thinking, and freedom. It makes use of a distinction between the “public use of reason” and the “private use of reason”. The latter is defined as the use of our reason when we functioning as a cog in the machine, which is to say, when we are speaking as a functionary of an official position which we’ve sworn to uphold. Examples of this for Kant would be pastors and ministers or priests, politicians (strangely enough, despite calling them public offices), or perhaps even as CEOs of companies, etc. The public use of reason, on the other hand, is when I speak as an individual, that is to say, when I

have the courage to use my own understanding to speak for myself. Kant says that humanity has become accustomed to immaturity in thinking because of cowardice and laziness, but that the public use of reason is the means by which mankind matures into free and independent thinking. This distinction between public and private therefore also mirrors Kant's distinctions elsewhere in his philosophy between the phenomena and noumena, theoretical reason and practical reason, rational theology and historical/biblical theology (general/particular revelation), etc. In each of these cases, Kant is subverting our usual expectation of the meaning of these terms. The importance of public reason cannot be overstated for Kant—he explicitly states that the private use of reason is to be permitted, only on the grounds that the public use of reason is not inhibited—"Argue as much as you will, but obey!" This is the foundation of Kant's social contract theory as well—the legitimate (rationale) of the state is in its support of reason and therefore his praise of Frederick the Great. Hence Kant concludes in this essay that we are in an age of enlightenment but not in an enlightened age; the distinction being that we are in an age where independent thinking has begun to take root but in an age where it has become the norm (hegemony).

Topic 2: Habermas - Enlightenment as an Unfinished Project

Habermas is a thinker associated with what is thought to be the second generation of the Frankfurt School theory of western Marxism, who are Marxists concerned with the problem of authoritarianism and fascism and the formation of types of subjects who are amenable to authoritarian regimes. The main thinkers associated with this school are Theodore Adorno and Max Horkheimer who wrote "dialectic of enlightenment" which is a book which attempts to reinterpret Hegel and Marx after the advent of thinkers like Nietzsche and Weber. They see Enlightenment, which was the process of reason, invert and collapse into a process of unreason because of nihilism and capitalism. They often claim that the goal of philosophy is to restore faith in reason after Auschwitz. Habermas own work is an extension of this project but also a

critique of the excessive pessimism of the prior generation. Instead of seeing Enlightenment as a failed project which must be redeemed (in a quasi theological fashion) he claims in his debate with Foucault that enlightenment and modernity are merely unfinished projects. Habermas thinking occurs in three phases throughout his career. The first phase is exemplified by his book "Structural Transformations in the Public Sphere" which attempts to recount how the public sphere which Kant discusses was borne and how the "colonization of the life world by the system" occurred. He recounts how the public sphere formed by the emerging bourgeoisie and their commercial interests leading to a new discovery of a universal humanity based in material interests leading to a new form of rationality but then how this subsequently became taken over by corporate interests, technology, the state and other forces. In his second phase he wrote a two part text called "The Theory of Communicative Rationality". This phase tries to take up the Kantian notion of a critique of reason which tried to found reason on a priori norms which are called the transcendental conditions of thinking and make it into a theory of communication. The warrant for this advancement comes from the way in which Kant was advanced by the neo-kantians who take the theory of the transcendental and who make it into a linguistic theory of how norms are articulated; which Habermas uses as a foundation for rethinking our political engagements in what he calls "discourse ethics". The last phase is exemplified by two books, "Between Facts and Norms" and "Another History of Philosophy". This phase occurred after Habermas debate with Cardinal Ratzinger who later became Pope Benedict XVI. Whereas Habermas early work emphasized the independence of the public sphere from religion, Ratzinger argued that the notion of the public sphere descended from Judeo-Christian values and argued that its foundations could not be maintained without religious norms. Hence, Habermas in his late work becomes especially concerned with the theological and spiritual foundations of reason and publicity and the need for a renewed engagement with religion.

Topic 3: Foucault - A commentary on Kant

Foucault is an interesting thinker whose work is often associated with the post-structuralist tendency in philosophy which Habermas once derided as “the young conservative” movement. Foucault’s early work is primarily concerned with the origins of psychiatry where he argues that reason and madness are co-terminus objects and that the invention of reason was concomitant with the invention of mental illness as leper colonies became replaced with asylums with the advent of modern medicine. As Foucault continues his project, he starts to attack the foundations of scientific knowledge in general, then makes a turn towards what he calls the “the discovery of biopolitics” which Agamben called Foucault’s discovery as him knocking on the door of the dead metaphysics of the western tradition. Here there is an argument regarding the origins of genocide, war, racism, and gender which Foucault believes comes from the way in which the Christian pastorate transformed notions of selfhood and truth in its transforming conceptions of sexuality. Hence Foucault argues that all modern forms of power, sovereign, disciplinary and biopolitical power, are rooted in the confessional, or the way in which power operates through the statements we make about our own identity. Hence power is not merely repressive, but about the production of the types of subjectivity which will govern themselves. This work also becomes important in the era of capitalism and neoliberalism where self-governance becomes the highest value of western society.

Foucault’s essay on Kant exemplifies this transition. Here, Foucault argues that he is not a “anti-modern” thinker as Habermas misconstrues him to be, but that he is a modernist and agrees with Habermas that Enlightenment is an unfinished project. However, his interpretation of Kant is that Kant is inaugurating us into a form of thinking of philosophy which is not about seeking pre-eternal truths, but rather in turning towards our contemporary world and, in this world, seeing what immortal truths we can draw from the flux of fashion. He focuses on a figure explored by Baudelaire which he calls the dandy, who is the fashionable man, who attempts to conform his style and thinking to the fashion of the age—this is an example of Kantian immaturity

of false modernity; instead, he reads Kant as enjoining us to an attempt to draw what is immortal from the flux of fashion.

Topic 4: Baha'Ullah, Independent Investigation, the three ages, and the Tablets to the Christian and the Tablets of Wisdom

I want to preface this section by saying I am a new student of the history of Bahai and am by no means an expert or learned in this endeavour. However, in my early studies in the Bahai Faith, I have seen some resemblances to ideas I've had previous exposure to; namely, the course of history as the work of the Abrahamic God, the idea that God has given us reason as bearers of the divine image (*imago dei*), the theory of three ages, which has roots in Christian ideas of the trinity and the work of the spirit, and the tablets to the Christians and tablets of Wisdom, which seem to enjoin the Bahai faith to the legacy of BOTH Jerusalem and Athens.

1. the course of history as the work of God
2. God has given us reason as *imago dei*
3. the theory of three ages
4. the tablet to the Christians
5. the tablet of Wisdom

In the Tablet of Wisdom Baha'Ullah states, "The essence and the fundamentals of philosophy have emanated from the Prophets" and states the following:

"After Socrates came the divine Plato who was a pupil of the former and occupied the chair of philosophy as his successor. He acknowledged his belief in God and in his signs which pervade all that hath been and shall be. Then came Aristotle, the well-known man of knowledge. He it is who discovered the power of geaseous matter. These men who stand out as leaders of the

people and are pre-eminent among them, one and all acknowledged their belief in the immortal Being Who holdeth in his grasp the reins of all sciences.” (147).

In this tablet, as I understand it, Baha’Ullah establishes that all truth and knowledge comes from God and emanates through his prophets, and seems to echo the scholastic philosophers sentiment said: *omne verum vero consonant*; all truth agrees with truth. This establishes a unique Bahai perspective, which I understand to be the “independent investigation of truth” namely that it is the responsibility of all thinkers to stand before God having developed their own conscience and having conceived of truth on their own terms, and not in terms that have been merely inherited or given to them by leaders and elders. There is something similar which occurs in the “Tablet to the Christians”. In this tablet, Baha’Ullah compares the rejection of subsequent prophets by other Abrahamic faiths to be similar to the rejection of Jesus by the pharisees who, in searching for the divine luminary everywhere else in the world, failed to see the light of the world as it entered in its time. Hence the pharisees were misled in relying on their own wisdom and understanding because they believed that their wisdom was an immortal inheritance of their ethnicity, and therefore failed to establish the living truth as it stood before them in person; which is to say, to establish it on the basis of their own good conscience and good deeds, rather than on the reception of the truth of their ancestors. But this is also a theme in the entire Abrahamic tradition; God approached Abraham not merely as a capricious God, but as a covenanting God, who allowed Abraham to reason with him, and to plead with him for the sake of humanity; God allowed Abraham to reason with him, and established with him a covenant, which would become the basis for a special, personal relationship to God and not merely a natural or inherited one. This was to acknowledge a teaching which also comes from Genesis of God as having established the divine image in humanity, and therefore of having given him reason so that not only despite but even through his earthly and animal nature he might be able to use his reason and intellect to approach God. The theory of the three ages, which start with the primitive, formative, and global ages also demonstrate this theme of

maturity, and coming to stand with God in terms of independent truth and reason, and not merely inherited truth.

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